Tufail Ahmed Sheikh

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Professional Summary

Engineering leader with 12+ years in network software and operations, including 7+ years leading India networking teams at **Extreme Networks**. Player-coach who hires and grows engineers, owns delivery and roadmaps, and sets technical direction for **network telemetry, inventory, and API platforms** *consumed by operators, customers, and AI agents. Hands-on across* **BGP/OSPF/MPLS/VLANs, streaming telemetry, SNMP/flow/syslog, Python APIs (REST/gRPC)**, and observability stacks (**Kafka, Prometheus, OpenTelemetry, Grafana**). Proven collaborating across US, EMEA, and APAC with product, platform, SRE, and Network Ops, strong on planning, risk, release management, and senior KPI reporting.

Currently leading network platform architecture for **Ford Motor Company** at **Blue Oval Michigan**, owning programme delivery, telemetry visibility, and API-driven access for a major manufacturing build-out.

Experience

Principal Architect - Network Platforms & Observability (APIs / Telemetry) — AHEAD — *Remote* — **31/12/2024 - Current**

Lead network platform architecture and programme delivery for a large-scale manufacturing transformation: connectivity, telemetry visibility, and API-driven access across cloud, network, and plant environments.

- Own end-to-end delivery for network platform workstreams at Ford Motor Company, Blue Oval Michigan, roadmaps, estimation, risk mitigation, release sequencing, and executive status/KPI reporting.
- Design policy and access APIs with versioning and contract clarity, exposing network capabilities to operators and automation.
- Integrate multi-source network and asset telemetry (inventory, IoT/OT visibility, streaming events, syslog) into queryable operational views for assurance and triage.
- Drive architecture and design reviews with platform, SRE, and Ops stakeholders; define SLOs, runbooks, on-call practice, and incident/RCA cycles for production services.
- Lead multi-vendor programme delivery (Palo Alto Prisma Access, IoT Security, XSOAR, Strata Cloud Manager), including resource planning and cross-timezone coordination with US teams.
- Champion engineering craft: peer review, testing before production, CI/CD-aligned change control, and continuous improvement of alerting quality and data accuracy.
- Partner with SRE and platform teams on observability pipeline health, infrastructure sizing, and production reliability for network services.
- Manage stakeholder communication, priority shifts, and escalations across business and engineering leaders.
- Prototype AI-assisted operational patterns, agent-ready tool/API exposure, RAG over runbooks and inventory, and faster critical-issue triage.

Head of Network Operations / SASE Product Head (India) — Extreme networks — *Remote* — **07/2017 – 30/12/2024**

- Hired, onboarded, coached, and retained engineers across levels; owned performance management, career pathways, and a tech-lead pipeline; set India team culture and operating rhythm from day one.
- Established engineering practices and delivery cadence for a distributed India team partnering daily with US and EMEA product, platform, and customer engineering counterparts.
- Owned end-to-end delivery of network platform and SASE programmes (major/minor/patch), planning, resource allocation, risk escalation with options, and senior-leadership KPI reporting.
- Set technical direction across observability/analytics (ExtremeAnalytics), inventory and control (ExtremeControl / Site Engine), fabric topology, and cloud-managed APIs (ExtremeCloud IQ, Platform ONE).
- Guided designs integrating streaming telemetry, SNMP/flow monitoring, topology, and inventory into reliable, queryable operator-facing platforms and APIs.
- Championed API design standards for network capabilities, REST interfaces, data modelling, versioning discipline, and contract testing with product engineering.
- Applied network domain depth (BGP, OSPF, MPLS, VLANs, SPB/Fabric Connect topology modelling) in architecture reviews, PoCs, and production troubleshooting.

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- Partnered with SRE/platform on observability pipelines, capacity sizing, alerting quality, and production health; led cross-functional incident response and repeat-issue remediation.
- Managed vendor and consulting resources alongside internal engineers; translated Ops and customer requirements into roadmaps and committed delivery plans.
- Represented the India organization in global forums and maintained strong working overlap with US and EMEA counterparts.
- Designed and operated data-center network estates spanning switching, security, facilities, and access control, grounding platform work in interconnection and DC operations.

Network Engineer — RUCKUS NETWORKS — *Bengaluru, KA, India* — **02/2016 - 07/2017**

- Designed, deployed, and operated enterprise wireless and access networks end to end, survey, segmentation, identity-based access, monitoring, and production handover.
- Built operational telemetry and health views for wireless estates (Zone Director / SmartZone); used monitoring data to drive capacity, reliability, and incident resolution.
- Wrote runbooks and trained client teams; partnered cross-functionally to release network capabilities with clear acceptance and support criteria.

IT Analyst Engineer — CISCO — *Bengaluru, KA, India* — **05/2014 - 10/2015**

- Built enterprise network and infrastructure experience at Cisco across routing/switching, remote access, and internal platforms.
- Supported Cisco ASA remote-access VPN and diagnosed Layer 1–7 network, voice, and application issues with engineering teams.
- Wrote runbooks, design notes, and operating procedures; contributed to internal projects deploying and validating network changes under production standards.

Education

Bachelor of Technology — LPU — *INDIA* — **08/2009 - 12/2013**

Computer Science Engineering

Core Skills

Leadership: hiring & people management, performance/career development, programme & release management, roadmaps, risk/KPI reporting, global stakeholders, vendor oversight, India engineering team build-out.
Network & telemetry: observability/NMS/EMS, automation & inventory, topology/CMDB-DCIM concepts, BGP, OSPF, MPLS, VLANs, SNMP, streaming telemetry/gNMI, NetFlow/IPFIX, syslog, datacenter & interconnection.
Observability stack: Kafka, Prometheus, OpenTelemetry, Grafana, Loki; SLOs, on-call, runbooks, incident response & RCA.
Software & APIs: Python, Java, REST/gRPC/GraphQL, data modelling, versioning, contract testing, CI/CD, code quality.
AI-native: LLM tool calling, agent-ready APIs, Model Context Protocol (MCP), RAG, AI-assisted troubleshooting.
Platforms: ExtremeCloud IQ / Platform ONE / Analytics / Control; Palo Alto SASE; AWS/Azure/GCP; Kubernetes basics.
Credentials: NVIDIA AI / DGX / Networking Technical Curricula (2025); Extreme Networks Cloud Engineer.